

◀ Amorous games

The Garden of Love, a 14th-century birthing tray, was used to carry gifts and food to new mothers while they recovered from childbirth. The painting shows male and female musicians around a well, in a scene of courtly love.



BIOGRAPHY

ELEANOR OF AQUITAINE

Eleanor was the most powerful woman of the Middle Ages. In 1137, she inherited the French Duchy of Aquitaine. That year she married Louis VI of France, and introduced his court to the rules of courtly love. The marriage was annulled in 1152; two years later Eleanor married Henry II of England, 11 years her junior. As queen she played a prominent part in politics, and she promoted courtly love and chivalry at the court in Poitiers.

to women of lower social rank. After knights captured besieged cities, rape, massacre, and pillage were common. Chivalric ideals also stood against the teachings of the Church, which taught its congregation to feel guilt over love and sexual behavior. However, courtly lovers did not view this as a sin; instead, they reveled in the pleasure of such experiences.

Women's experiences of chivalry

Courtly love was usually recorded in song. Stories were told in courts and in taverns by itinerant musicians—known as a Minnesinger in German, or a troubadour in Occitania (part of modern Italy and France), Spain, and Italy. The existence of the female term *trobairitz* shows that

women also made music in this way, and *trobairises* such as Tibors de Sarenom and the Comtessa de Diá became some of the first female composers in the history of secular music.

Only a small number of works about courtly love by women have survived. Among these are the narrative poems of Marie de France, who lived in England in the late 12th century. Her work skewered male attitudes that fighting solved all problems. In “The Unfortunate One,” three knights hold a tournament to win a lady, but two of them die and the survivor is left impotent by a lance wound—proof that the glamorized ideals of courtly love did not live up to the brutal realities of medieval life.